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Nº. 46

LIFE SITUATIONS

COLLECTION

Retirement and Real Estate

Downsizing, income and estate planning — make real estate work for your retirement.



2026 EDITION

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It presents general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. Every real estate situation is different, and you should consult the appropriate professionals before making a decision about a transaction.

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Retirement, Real Estate and Downsizing · Collection Life Situations · Guide No. 46 · 2026 Edition

COLLECTION LIFE SITUATIONS · GUIDE NO. 46

Retirement, Real Estate and Downsizing

Downsize, free up cash and make real estate work for retirement

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As you approach or during retirement, your property often becomes your main asset - and a lever for quality of life. Reduce size (downsizing), free up cash or generate income: several options are available to you.

This guide explores real estate strategies for retirement, with their advantages and points to watch out for.

Informative content, not financial advice: consult your advisors. Each chapter ends with a lined “My Notes” page.

As you approach or during retirement, your property often becomes your main asset - and a lever for quality of life. This guide explores downsizing, ways to generate income, the transfer and adaptation of housing for aging in place.

Informative content, not financial advice: consult the professionals concerned.

CHAPTER

Downsizing: reducing to live better

> *Weigh the benefit of reducing the size.*

Selling a large house for a smaller property (condo, smaller house) can transform your daily life.

- Less maintenance, taxes and energy costs.
- Potential liquidity released by the price difference.
- A simplified life, often better adapted.

It is often a choice of **quality of life** as much as financial. To evaluate all the same: transaction and moving costs, and attachment to the house.

Selling a large house for a smaller one (condo, reduced house) reduces maintenance, taxes and energy, frees up cash flow and simplifies life. It is often a quality of life choice as much as a financial one; weigh transaction costs and attachment to home.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Downsizing is not just about money. Many retirees tell me above all that they have saved time and peace of mind. Weigh the comfort of life as much as the financial calculation.*

CHAPTER

Generate income or free up cash

> *Put your real estate assets to work.*

Your property can become a lever of income in retirement:

- **Downsizing + placement** : invest the difference for income.
- **Income property** : generate rents (with the management that this implies).
- **Enhancement of equity** of the residence (certain loans adapted to seniors): to be examined with caution.

Each option has tax and risk implications: the objective is income *sustainable*, not a bet.

Your property can become a lever of income: downsizing + investment of the difference, income property (with the management that this implies), or solutions for enhancing equity (to be examined with caution). Each option has tax and risk implications: aim for sustainable income, not a gamble.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Be wary of "miracle" solutions to turn your house into cash. Some are expensive in long-term interest. Always have it validated by an independent advisor.*

CHAPTER

Think about transmission and the long term

> *Integrate real estate into your estate planning.*

Your property is part of the **heritage** that you will transmit. Thinking about it early avoids many complications for your loved ones:

- **Will** up to date.
- **Taxation** of the estate.
- **Equity** between heirs.

Coordinate your real estate decisions with your overall financial and estate planning, ideally with a notary and a planner.

Your property is part of the heritage to be transmitted: thinking early about the transmission (will, inheritance taxation, equity between heirs) avoids complications for your loved ones. Talk about it during your lifetime: a house to be shared between several children is a classic source of conflict.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Talk about your intentions to your loved ones during your lifetime. A house that must be shared between several children is a classic source of conflict - which clarity easily prevents.*

CHAPTER

Staying at home: adapting the property

> *Aging at home safely.*

Not everyone wants to move. Staying in your own property can be a great choice, provided you**adapt** :

- Reduce **obstacles** (steps, thresholds, bathtub).
- Improve **lighting** and **security** (grab bars, non-slip).
- Provide for**interview** entrusted to services if necessary.

Anticipating these arrangements means peacefully prolonging the pleasure of living at home.

Staying at home can be an excellent choice, provided you adapt the property: reduce obstacles (steps, thresholds, bathtub), improve lighting and security, provide delegated maintenance. These arrangements cost little and change everything for aging at home in safety.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Small safety features cost little and change everything for aging at home. Think about it before you need it: a suitable bathroom is better than an avoidable fall.*

CHAPTER

Building your real estate retirement strategy

> *Decide according to your quality of life and your safety.*

There is no single solution: the right strategy is the one that corresponds to YOUR situation. A simple process:

1. **Clarify** your needs (space, costs, income, autonomy).
2. **Estimate** the equity in your property.
3. **Compare** options (downsizing, income, staying at home).
4. **Coordinate** with your financial and estate plan.

Decide with professional lighting, but always according to your life priorities.

There is no single solution: the right strategy corresponds to YOUR situation. Start with “how do I want to live my retirement?” ”, then follow up with real estate. Estimate your net worth, compare options and coordinate with your financial and estate plan.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Start with the question “how do I want to live my retirement?” ”, then follow up with real estate. The house is a means of serving your life project, not the other way around.*

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

> *Your next steps, concretely.*

This week

1. Clarify my retirement needs (space, costs, income).
2. Estimate the equity in my property.

Within 30 days

1. Explore downsizing and income options with an advisor.
2. Review my estate planning with a notary.

Then

1. Decide on a strategy aligned with my quality of life and my safety.

For my strategy

1. Clarify my retirement needs and estimate my home equity.
2. Compare downsizing, income and staying at home with an advisor.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Downsizing: move to a smaller, less expensive property.
- Equity: equity value of the property, which can be mobilized with caution.
- Retirement income: what can an investment or rental property support.
- Estate planning: integration of real estate into the will.
- Independent advisor: neutral professional to evaluate options.

- Downsizing: moving to a smaller, less expensive property.
- Equity: equity value of the property, which can be mobilized with caution.
- Estate planning: integration of real estate into the will.
- Maintenance at home: adapting housing to age at home.
- Independent advisor: neutral professional to evaluate options.

GO FURTHER

Quiz - test yourself

1. Downsizing consists of:

A) Enlarge your house
B) Downgrade to a smaller, less expensive property
C) Buy a building
D) Rent a chalet

2. Downsizing can bring:

A) More maintenance
B) Less costs and liquidity
C) More taxes
D) No change

3. An income property generates:

A) No income
B) Rents, with the management that this implies
C) Taxes only
D) Insurance

4. Solutions to enhance equity must be:

A) Signed without thinking
B) Examined with caution and advice
C) Always avoided
D) Free

5. The property is part of:

A) Of no heritage
B) Heritage to be transmitted
C) Taxes only
D) Insurance

6. To avoid inheritance conflicts, you must:

A) Say nothing
B) Clarify your intentions (will, discussion)
C) Sell everything in secret
D) Wait

7. Staying at home often requires:

A) Don’t change anything
B) Adapt the property (security, obstacles)
C) Move
D) Rent

8. Security arrangements:

A) Cost a fortune
B) Cost little and change a lot
C) Are useless
D) Are prohibited

9. The right real estate retirement strategy is:

A) The same for everyone
B) The one aligned with your situation and your priorities
C) Always sell
D) Always keep

10. Real estate, upon retirement, should be:

A) The ultimate goal
B) A means to serve your life project
C) Ignored
D) Decided by the children

Answers

1. B - Reduce the size (chap. 1).
2. B - Less costs, liquidity (chap. 1).
3. B - Rents and management (chap. 2).
4. B - Caution and independent advice (chap. 2).
5. B - Inheritance assets (chap. 3).
6. B - Clarity and testament (chap. 3).
7. B - Adapt housing (chap. 4).
8. B - Inexpensive, very useful (chap. 4).
9. B - Adapted to each person (chap. 5).
10. B - A means, not an end (chap. 5).

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You now have the right keys in hand.

Every real estate journey is different.

If you would like to go further,
I would be happy to discuss
your project with you.



Make informed decisions.
Choose with confidence.
Live without regrets.
See you soon,
Emilie ☺

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